Earth Day

After witnessing a horrific oil spill in California, in 1969, US Senator Gaylord Nelson decided to focus on growing worries about pollution during a national “teach-in” on the environment. He could not have envisioned the size of the movement he would inspire. On April 22, 1970, 20 million Americans took part in the first Earth Day, with rallies, marches, and lectures nationwide. Such was the effect of the protests in the US that later that year the Clean Air, Clean Water, and Endangered Species Acts became law, and the Environmental Protection Agency was created. Earth Day became a global phenomenon, with 200 million people in 141 countries taking part in 1990—and built momentum for the 1992 UN Earth Summit in Rio de Janeiro. Earth Day celebrations are held every April, with a different theme each time. In 2025, the 55th anniversary of Earth Day, the theme was “Our power, our planet,” which focused on rapid renewable energy deployment.